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Culture (OWC): [Gikuyu \(FL10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1983-1984, 1992, 1994

Coverage Date: 1910-1995

Place Coverage: Mutira, Central Province, Kenya

Section Title(S): 5 Watoro's Story: Poverty Is Like Dust

That is the end of the story. You see, a hospitable woman is the one who, when she marries away and meets young children, she takes care of them as her own. Our grandmother told us that if one marries she should not go abusing the children she meets, and when she cooks, she should give food to all children she meets. We were told, "*Gūtanaha na kūigwanira tha mūdū ndagaga mwo*" ["To be hospitable and merciful to others, one will not miss somebody to collect her"—help her in times of need.].

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Transmission Of Cultural Norms

As a child I was very playful, but I wouldn't provoke other children as some do. I remember we sang and danced a lot. We had one type of play where we would pass a ball around a circle of us, singing, "*Marombo na Mwarau*" three times, then "*Mwendi gūceca nīa cece rīngī*" [The one who wants to play can play again], then "*Marombo na Mwarau*" again as we passed the ball around.

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Ethnobotany

When I grew up to be about four or five—still a child— a *mūdū mugo* slaughtered a goat, and the skin was spread out for a bed for me, and *rūkoro* [a strip of goat's skin] was put around me. It was taken off the next day, after it had hardened. The elders gathered for the ceremony, then ate the goat's meat to celebrate. We called this *mambura ma twana* [ceremony of the children]. It usually occurred when the mother wanted to remove the youngest child from her bed so she could have sexual relations with her husband again and get another child. Up to that time, a child would sleep with the mother until it was weaned—no matter how big. All this time, the father was staying in his *thingira*. I don't remember too much about *mambura ma twana* because I was still small, but I was told about it.

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The first major changes that I remember were *mbuci* and *matũ*; then, after these healed and I grew up some more and showed signs of growing breasts, I was circumcised. Then I was a grown person and could go to dances during the night. After many dances, when I was more mature and had begun to menstruate ,I got married. Later, I separated from my husband and went back to my father's home—these were the big changes in my life that I remember clearly.

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When I was about fifteen, that is when I went to my mother and told her I wanted *mbuci*. The reason I wanted my ears pieced was for beauty and putting on beads and decorative metals. Also, one would not be very happy to see her agemates with decorations in her ears while she had none. The ones who did not have their ears pierced were like fools, because they were trying to cut themselves off from the community. We would not joke with them, nor could they joke about with us.

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